

Introduction

The last time we gave a Fast Track to Linux, Linux was still something only for geeks, and a fairly complicated undertaking. Linux has changed a lot since then, and evolved furiously as an OS that can give competition to the likes of Windows and OS X. Most prominently, the Ubuntu distribution (or distro) has become one of the most widely used Linux distributions. If any Windows user wants to switch to a Linux distro, Ubuntu is the distro that person is most likely to try out. Ubuntu lives up to its claim as being Linux for human beings, but what has helped the proliferation most are the free DVDs and CDs that are mailed to users by the parent company. Almost any net user moderately interested in technology has tried out a Live CD of Ubuntu at one point of time or another.

At the same time, other important distributions have evolved too. This includes OpenSUSE, Mandriva (formerly Mandrake) and Sabayon. Gone are the days when running a Linux operating system meant that most of the operations had to be managed through the command line. The Linux Desktop, in other words, the GUIs have also evolved, with Gnome, KDE and XFCE establishing themselves, and providing as much eye candy as Vista or OS X in their latest releases. The onset of Web 2.0 has provided the open source community with more tools to converge and co-ordinate their efforts, which has increased the amount of tools available for Linux by leaps and bounds.

What this means for the end user is that Linux has arrived. There are versions of Linux that are idiot friendly, versions of Linux that make you feel at home in a Windows-like environment, and even versions of Linux that come with propriety codecs included.

One of the biggest apprehensions about Linux is that its free so it must be bad. This is untrue. Consider the work on the source codes of Linux distros and programs as a large wiki. Since mistakes and bugs can be seen by everyone, they get ironed out quickly. A passion for working at it, and creating a software that can outdo a commercial version has resulted in a lot of quality software for Linux.

These vary from multimedia editing, enterprise management, database management, scientific tools, computer aided design